

A MAGNIFICENT SEVEN

For all its historic interest, Boston is a bit short of official landmarks. The *Globe's* architecture critic here offers some candidates for the honor.

By Robert Campbell

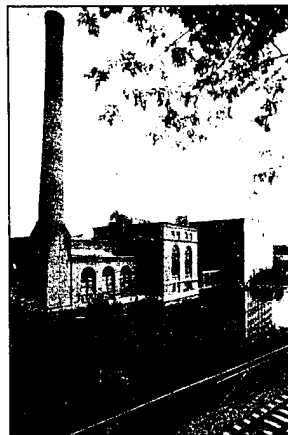
Boston has exactly twenty-eight architectural landmarks. At least, that's the total officially designated in the six years since the Boston Landmarks Commission was established. It doesn't seem quite a high enough number in a city famous for its history and for its architecture.

The problem is not that the Landmarks Commission is lazy. The commission and its staff work hard. The problem, rather, is that the commission keeps getting embroiled in time-consuming battles over development proposals. Every time a developer proposes another forty-story tower for our already overbuilt downtown, his opponents try to get the Landmarks Commission to stop him by declaring that

ROBERT CAMPBELL, A CAMBRIDGE ARCHITECT, IS THE ARCHITECTURE CRITIC OF THE *GLOBE*.



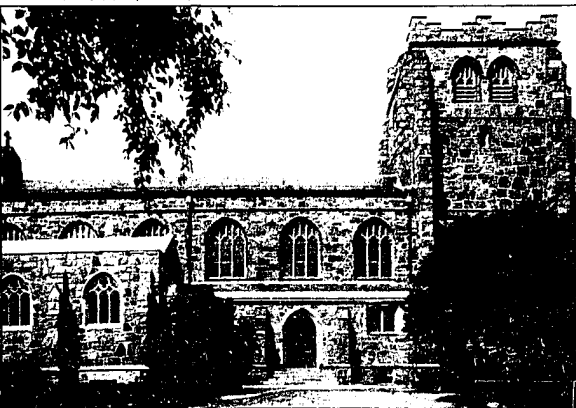
THE AMES BUILDING, BOSTON



DORCHESTER LOWER MILLS



THE PARAMOUNT THEATER, BOSTON



ALL SAINTS CHURCH, DORCHESTER



THE SHIRLEY-EUSTIS HOUSE, ROXBURY



THE MORE RECENT OF THE TWO CHESTNUT HILL PUMPING STATIONS IS IN THE BEAUX-ARTS CLASSICAL STYLE. RARE IN BOSTON

some old building in his way is a landmark. Once it is a landmark, a building can't be demolished.

The Landmarks Commission thus has become a kind of court that mediates between developers and preservationists. It's a valuable role, but one that doesn't have a lot to do with the orderly process of designating landmarks. What landmarks the commission has named have usually been the buildings most threatened, not those most deserving (though all have certainly been deserving).

The commission, to be sure, is working hard to catch up. It's well along on the gargantuan task of surveying every building in the entire city and rating those that might deserve to be landmarks. Surveys of the downtown, Dorchester, Allston-Brighton, and the South End are already complete.

But there's still a long way to go. So, by way of nudging the commission and reminding us all of the amazing richness of architecture Boston has to offer, I've compiled a short list of suggested landmarks. Just to hint at how broad the possibilities are, I've

picked a house, a church, a theater, a commercial sign, an office building, a public utility, and an industrial complex.

I've left off the list all the icons, the national treasures like King's Chapel and Faneuil Hall that nobody is going to tear down anyway. The idea is to suggest a sample — a tiny sample — of some of the less well-known but equally deserving landmarks.

The Shirley-Eustis House, Roxbury.

This enormous, utterly spectacular house has been practically vacant, inhabited only by a caretaker, since 1911. It was the home of two governors of Massachusetts — William Shirley, in the 1740s, and William Eustis, in the 1820s — and it is the only surviving house in the United States that was occupied by a Colonial governor.

The architecture of the Shirley-Eustis house is as interesting as its history. Shirley built it as a classic example of the Georgian style. Eustis then remodeled it in the Federal style, carving out larger rooms and a vast stair hall with a sweeping curved stair.

Eventually the house declined. In 1867 it became a rooming house, and later it was moved sixty feet to make room for a new street. The interior today is a wreck. Yet much fine detail survives, including ornamental plaster, inlaid railings, and paneling from both the Georgian and Federal eras. There's a belvedere up on the roof with views out over much of the city.

Now, at last, renovation is in progress, under the auspices of the Shirley-Eustis House Association and architect Robert Neiley, and the mansion should be open to visitors in a couple of years.

All Saints' Church, Dorchester. This was the first church designed by Ralph Adams Cram and Bertram Grosvenor Goodhue, the architects who almost single-handedly made the Gothic style of the Middle Ages the standard for two generations of American churches and for many college campuses as well.

Cram went on to design much of Princeton and West Point and the Cathedral of Saint John the Divine in New York. But All Saints', finished in 1894, has a rough freshness

and strength that his later work often lacks. Cram never stopped improving the church. He added new chapels in 1912 and 1929 and worked with sculptors, stained-glass craftsmen, and goldsmiths to embellish the church.

The result is a free, bold, original design that improvises on the theme of an English village church. The dark, brooding tower of rough Quincy granite has great power. Inside, simple white plaster walls and oak-timbered ceilings set off the rich decorations.

All Saints' isn't particularly endangered, but that almost makes it an exception. As a group, no Boston landmarks are more threatened than the churches. Membership is down, maintenance costs are up, and even some of the famous churches, such as architect H. H. Richardson's Brattle Square Church in Back Bay, are said to be headed for trouble. The Landmarks Commission plans a special survey to assess the problem.

The Paramount Theater, Washington Street. The Paramount is a rarity in Boston, one of the few buildings

to go up here during the economic doldrums of the thirties and forties. That makes it one of the few examples we have of the dominant style of that era, the style called Art Deco.

Art Deco is a kind of marriage of modern and classical architecture. It tends toward buildings that step back as they rise, with zig-zag geometrical ornament or streamlined curving corners. It's the style of sophisticated thirties movies, the style of the great ocean liners, the Radio City Music Hall, and the Chrysler and Empire State buildings.

Boston has its Fox store on Washington Street, the United Shoe Company Building, the Batterymarch Building, No. 29 Franklin Street, the old John Hancock tower, and a few more, but nothing compared with New York. There's more Deco in the suburbs than in Boston.

The Paramount is probably Boston's most elaborate Art Deco building and is its only Deco theater. Designed by Arthur Bowditch, a prominent Boston architect, in 1932, it has a spectacular facade, now partly obscured but restorable, with a wonder-

ful Hollywood-hectic sign. In the interior nearly everything survives, right down to the lounge furniture. The lobby walls are inlaid oriental walnut and ebony. The proscenium is bordered in gold leaf. Twelve murals of courtly scenes, painted in pastel on canvas, line the auditorium.

The Paramount is currently boarded up. The city took it for taxes in 1980. Its future is uncertain. But this is one we don't want to lose.

The Citgo sign, Kenmore Square. There's a petition from a citizens' group asking the Landmarks Commission to consider the Citgo sign, and by the time this article appears it may be on its way to being a landmark. I hope so. No structure of its period in Boston deserves it more.

This magnificent illuminated sign once pulsed like an electric heart in the night sky over Kenmore Square, its blue and red reflected in the Charles River basin. But it was turned off, at the request of the Edward J. King administration, in 1979, a purely symbolic response to the energy crisis. Now the sign is deteriorating.

Boston has few illuminated signs. The Coca-Cola sign on the Charles seems safe now, after surviving a threat, but the White Fuel sign in Kenmore Square is gone. Many people feel snobbish about the great signs, but surely the monuments of our automobile era are as legitimate as those of any other time. And the Citgo sign is the best symbol

In those days,
Boston spent a
third of its
annual budget
on water works.

Boston possesses of that whole period in American cultural history, the age of seeming abundance, exuberance, and power, the age of the automobile and the open road — an era that may rapidly be ending.

Citgo is also a superb example of the bold graphic design of the sixties, a kind of commercial folk art. It's a landmark by which people have oriented themselves to our confusing town ever since

it was erected. If it goes, there won't be any more like it.

At last word, Cities Service wanted to tear the sign down because it would cost too much to fix up. A merger of the company with Gulf Oil may be in the works, though, and no one knows what may happen.

The Ames Building, Court Street. This is Boston's first skyscraper and one of its handsomest. For a quarter of a century, from 1889 through 1914, it was Boston's tallest structure (the Customs House Tower finally beat it out). Yet the Ames doesn't even have a modern steel frame. It's built the old way, of one stone piled on top of another. It remains today, at thirteen stories, the second-tallest building in the world with traditional masonry bearing walls, after the Monadnock in Chicago. The stone is Milford granite on the lower three floors, Ohio sandstone above. Originally, the elevator was pushed up and down by a hydraulic plunger sunk 126 feet into rock.

The Ames was designed by the firm founded by the great Boston architect H. H.

"Compliments of the management, gentlemen—a magnum of Riunite to celebrate reaching the tippy-top!"



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Riunite on ice...that's nice. America's best-loved imported wine.
Soft and Light. Pure and Natural. Red, White and Rosé. Imported from Italy.

Richardson. The firm, still in business as Shepley, Bulfinch, Richardson and Abbott, is the oldest continuing practice in the United States. It now has its office in the Ames, but, moving cautiously with the times, is about to decamp to a newer building it designed in 1923.

The Ames Building's exterior has Richardson's massive stone and bold arches, like those of his Trinity Church, but it's much busier, much more ornate, than the master's own work. It has always been admired: The leading architecture critic of the time, Montgomery Schuyler, called it "a building of moderate area and immoderate altitude," but he said it handled these difficult proportions "with brilliant success."

Downtown Boston is filled with elegant office buildings of about the same era as the Ames. My other favorite is the Winthrop Building of 1893 at Water and Devonshire streets. Boston's first steel-frame building, beautifully clad in orange brick and brown terra cotta.

The Chestnut Hill Pumping Stations, Brighton. These are

two of the loveliest buildings in Boston, and they stand in a magical parklike setting, surrounded by equally remarkable small support buildings and gatehouses. The overall effect is similar to that of an English landscape park like the famous garden at Stowe near Oxford — the buildings stand like ornamental pavilions in a romantic setting of rolling meadow and pond, an amazing sight in the middle of a twentieth-century metropolis.

The two stations are wholly unlike each other, but each is a superb example of its style. The older one is Richardsonian Romanesque, blocky pink granite with brown trim and a green copper roof. It was built only a couple of years after the death of H. H. Richardson by Arthur Vinal, then the Boston City Architect. The newer station, in pale Indiana limestone, was designed in 1901 in the so-called Beaux-Arts Classical style, a style (rare here) named for the Ecole des Beaux-Arts school of architecture in Paris. The style was popularized here by the Columbian Exposition in Chicago of 1893. The architects

who ignored the Richardsonian precedent to build this station were, again, Richardson's own successors; the firm was then called Shepley, Ruten and Coolidge.

Before the discovery of germs, fresh air and fresh water were thought to be the basis of health. In a frenzy to achieve fresh water, Boston spent a third of its annual budget on water works in the latter decades of the nineteenth century. But the Chestnut Hill site was meant to be a health-giving open-air recreational facility as well as a utility. An 1878 guidebook brags that it is "a great pleasure resort" and "the most popular drive in the city."

Inside the older station is a steam pump famous in its own right. Designed by a noted engineer, Erasmus Darwin Leavitt, the pump is two stories high and trimmed with brass. Obsolete now, it is a National Historic Mechanical Engineering Landmark. A scale model of the pump stands in the Smithsonian Institution in Washington, D.C., where it is seen by a lot more people than see the original.

The Chestnut Hill Sta-

tions are still in use, but in a standby capacity. A study a few years back suggested a mix of new uses, including offices for the Water Board and a museum featuring the old pumps. But so far nothing has been done.

Incidentally, another pumping station, the one out on Columbia Point, built in 1883, runs Chestnut Hill a close second as an architectural monument. A scheme to make it a University of Massachusetts bookstore fell through a few years ago. It has one of Boston's fantastic interior spaces and is another potential landmark.

Dorchester Lower Mills, Dorchester. The Mills complex is easily the outstanding historic industrial complex in Boston. It's a group of buildings of unusual handsomeness in a rugged, steep natural site of puddingstone ledges.

The first chocolate factory was started here by Dr. James Baker in 1765, by which time the rapids of the Neponset River were already a favored industrial location. Cotton, paper, corn, and textiles were milled too, but chocolate be-

came the major product. Sixteen brick buildings remain, a few of them on the Milton side of the river, of which fourteen were part of the chocolate company owned by Walter Baker (James's grandson). Most were built between 1872 and 1935, many of them, once again, in the Romanesque style of H. H. Richardson. There's also an eighteen-silo grain elevator, a major visual accent for the neighborhood.

Most of the buildings came from one architectural firm: Walter Winslow, Nathaniel Bradlee, and their successors over a period of forty-three years. Especially

handsome are the Adams Street Mill (1889), which curves grandly around a turn in Adams Street, and the Mason Regulator Company building (now Fabreeka Products) with its corner turret.

Baker Chocolate became a part of General Foods, but the company remained on this site until 1965, when it moved to Delaware, taking eight hundred jobs from the area. Most of the buildings have found new uses, and the rocky, wooded Neponset River bank looks much as it did a half-century ago, a monument to the industrial past that once was a foundation of New England's greatness. ■



The Citgo sign in Kenmore Square "once pulsed like an electric heart in the night sky."

Stan Grossfeld

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